

Ayo olopon & other games

Some newly described mancala games
from southwestern Nigeria



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Abstract

This paper describes in detail the rules of 7 mancala games and other 4 variants reported during a fieldwork on July 2009 in southwestern Nigeria. Most of these games have never been reported or described. *Ayo olopon* is the manner how Yoruba people call oware game. Nowadays if you have the opportunity to travel to southwestern Nigeria you can see elders and youth playing Ayo olopon and other mancala games on their streets distributing simple counters one by one in successive holes around the board.

Key words: mancala, ayo olopon, awale, oware, ayo, jekinge, olowuka, sokusowo, odu, jodu, redu, Yoruba.

¹ Fieldwork about Ayo olopon and other mancala games performed by Vicenta Canal, Bernat Casanovas and Jordi Climent on July 2009 in Lagos and other cities and towns in southwestern Nigeria.

Introduction

The day after the arrival in Nigeria we went to Spanish consulate in Lagos. A woman (the consul) received us very kindly, with a puzzled face when she saw us there, because people of the south-western Nigeria that we visited few days later did not received visits of foreigners for a long time. The consul asked us with very curiosity: "Why do you come to this country?" While she checked our visas we told her: "We have come here expressly to do a research on mancala games".



Figs.1 and 2: Ayo olopon boards from Nigeria. Private collection of Bernat Casanovas.

The generic name "Mancala" is conventionally used by some authors and researchers to refer to a family of traditional games which are usually played on wooden boards with several rows of holes. Sometimes the boards are carved of other materials such as ivory, metal, clay or stone. In some cases mancala boards are dug in the sand or rocks, or drawn on the floor. Mancala games have been played for hundreds or perhaps thousands of years. These games have different

names, rules, strategies, styles of play and goals that can vary from one region to another.

At least there are 300 different mancala games. These are widespread across the Africa's continent and much of Asia, and also in the Caribbean and the Americas and parts of Europe. Mancala games not always are played between two players. Sometimes two teams fight against each other. At other times three, four or more players play on a board with two rows of six or seven holes and each player controls one section or a group of holes. On rare occasions, the number of players determines the number of holes, usually arranged in rows, drawn or scooped out of the ground.



Figs.3 and 4: Ayo olopon boards from Nigeria. Private collection of Bernat Casanovas.

Boards have several rows of holes through which seeds or other small pieces are distributed (beans, stones, pebbles, shells, dried animal dung or cowries). Currently are also used other materials as counters: pieces of plastic or wood, glass beads, etc. The size of the counters, their color and shape are not important. At the start of the game a specific number of counters are usually

placed into each hole of the board. The number of playing pieces varies according to the rules of the game.



Fig.5: CLIMENT, J. 2012 *Alguns dels jocs mancala al món*, In: *Món aulalé* 1(3) pp.4-7 [online] Mancala games have been played and are still played throughout Africa's continent and much of Asia, and also in the Caribbean and the Americas and parts of Europe.

The basic moves of mancala games are called "**sowing**" and "**harvesting**". The **sowing** means to distribute or to place the seeds one by one in consecutive holes. That is, consists in to pick up the seeds contained in any hole in the own side and to distribute these, one by one, around the board. In some particular games a single seed cannot be used to begin a move or a player may move a single seed only in some circumstances. In most cases a player must to move picking up the contents of any hole in the own row and placed one by one into the ensuing holes. In some games the contents are placed commencing in the hole which the seeds are picked up. There are differences in how and when the harvesting is done. Depending on the type of sowing, we can distinguish "**sowing with simple lap**" and "**sowing with multiple laps**". Sowing with a simple lap means that a player picks up the contents of a hole in its own territory and these are sown.

Then the turn ends when the player runs out of seeds in hand. While "sowing with multiple laps" begins in the same way that "sowing with a simple lap" but the turn not necessarily ends when the player runs out of seeds in hand. The turn ends when the player who is sowing falls into an empty hole or when a capture is performed. That is, in "sowing with multiple laps" some "simple laps" are chained. Depending on the type of turn of play, we can distinguish "**sowing with alternative turns of play**" (is most widespread) or "**with simultaneous turns of play**" (is usually used in some regions at the beginning of the game as a race to decide which player starts the second lap).



Fig.6: The author is playing Ayo olopon in Lagos, Nigeria. Photo: Vicenta Canal. July 4th 2009.

The harvesting consists of capturing one or more seeds contained in one or more holes in accordance with the rules of each game. In a specific group of mancala games, the captured seeds are removed from the board or placed in a bigger hole called "storehouse" usually situated at each end of the board, if there are. In another group of mancala games, the captured seeds instead to remove them from the board are reintroduced, that is, are deposited in the own territory if these come from the adversary holes, or are deposited in the territory of the

opponent if these come from the own territory. Reintroduction of seeds at harvesting is characteristic of games with three and four rows of holes but also can be found in games with two rows.²

In the Yoruba-speaking areas, the board game is called **olopon** and the seeds: **omo ayo**. Ayo and omo ayo terms are used in Yoruba's proverbs talking about perseverance, endurance and confidence in oneself, wit, boldness, wisdom, good judgment, etc. This illustrates that Ayo game is very popular and well-known among the Yoruba people. As we saw in some suburbs of Lagos in southwestern Nigeria, you can find men from northern populations playing ayo. Play help both players and spectators to hear about news, get information and be aware of local gossip, while are talking about anything around the game board. Indeed, around the board it is also remember the debts. Spectators will follow with interest the development of different games played. Just have to see how the veteran players play ayo olopon and other mancala games. It is interesting not only because of the strategy used to move the seeds but also because of the skill and speed of the moves when a player is sowing, and when the accumulated seeds into the holes in each side of board are hidden with the hand. When is the opponent player's turn, the player can put his hand on top of a hole in the side itself of the board, and can hid how many seeds there are. Also when is the player's turn, this player can count the contained seeds in one of the own holes, picking up from this hole and showing these seeds to the public but not to the opponent player, hiding these before returning to the hole. In short, these are some licenses that are allowed to veteran players for intimidate the opponent. Some players play for the spectators which are a lot. And it is a great show. They allow you to play against them and will explain you the different local games. The number of spectators and the curiosity to see a white man playing increase remarkably. If you win a game (as in my case) you become almost a celebrity and the defeated local player is the focus of teasing by their friends and neighbors.

² As in the case of Ohojichi game played in Ivory Coast. The aim of this Mancala game is to pass all the seeds from the side itself to the opponent player's holes. If the last seed falls in a hole containing 4 seeds, with the last one that is sown, these are captured and placed into one hole of the opponent. Enchained captures are allowed if there is any hole containing 4 seeds in a continuous line preceding this hole in the own side of the board. [<http://www.awale.info/africa-occidental/ohojitxi/?lang=en>]

Data collection and classification methods

The research presented in this paper focuses on intensive exploration of some cases (11 olopon games).

Undertake a research involves various methods and techniques of data collection, whether reading, observations, questions, or a combination of strategies. To choose one method or another depends on the discipline, the goals set and the type of research. Rather than the object of study, investigations differ in methodology. Methodology means a process that follows the research.



Fig. 7: Interview to Adedigba Abbis in Ilobu on July 21th, 2009. Recording by Bernat Casanovas.

As main research method we allow for the concept of **Ethnography** that is the work performed by a qualitative researcher in the fieldwork when observes and participates in a certain cultural phenomenon. The most used techniques of data collection were **observation**, **interviews**, and **records**.

Observation is the inspection and study of a particular subject through the senses. Observation may be more or less structured and gives immediacy and accuracy in the research. However, it has some drawbacks. On the one hand, the result of observation may be lost if it is not recorded on time with some means. On the other hand, it is a very slow method for collecting data. This problem can be avoided if it starts to categorize and structure observations before, even if it means losing some details. For the recording of the observations, we have provided technological means as photography, image recording and note taking.



Fig.8: Playing Ayo game in Ilobu on July 21th, 2009. Recording by Bernat Casanovas.

Some criteria that are often used for categorization of mancala games are not rigorous or accurate and therefore are not useful when describing them. To classify should not be a goal in itself but should be a tool to collect information and compare games that show similarities or differences.

When a game is described we allow for the context in which it is played, and many unique aspects that are targeted in this article. It make sense when a particular mancala game is described to say that is played on a board 2x8, 3x6 or 4x8, i.e., a board of two rows with eight holes, three rows with four holes or six

rows with eight holes. Or if it is played on a wooden board or digging the holes in the ground or in the sand. Or if it is played with seeds, shells or goat droppings, etc.. It is necessary to know as much information as possible but only relevant information which is important for the knowledge and dissemination of the game. Similarly when fruits are not grouped by color or smell, but by other criteria such as type of seed produced, the time of their collection (fresh or dried) or another criteria, with mancala games is the same: it makes little sense to classify these games only for certain aesthetic or for their shape, the type of wood or material that are cut, the number of rows with holes that contain. These are characteristics that alone do not give us enough information. These only collect anecdotal aspects.

Any description of a mancala game should contain at least the following information: name of the game and alternative names (how the game is also known), meaning of the name, where it is played, who play it (by male, female, young, old, children,...) and when it is usually played, number of rows and holes in the board, number of players, number of seeds in each hole at the beginning of the game, direction of movement, type and how the sowing is performed, type and number of counters used, how and where the harvesting is performed, the goal of the game, how and when the game ends.

Overview

- **11 olopon games** are described (all played on wooden boards with 2 rows of 6 holes). All **games** were **reported in 8 venues in southwestern Nigeria**: Lagos, Ibadan, Abeokuta, Ilesha, Oshogbo, Ile-Ife, Ilobu and Oyo.
 - **7 different games** whose:
 - **4 games never had been reported** or described:
 - *jekinke, sokusowo, olowuka, redu*.
 - **3 games well known** and also played in other countries with other names:
 - *jenje o ayo, jodu, odu*.
 - **4 variants or other manners to call the previous 3 games** already well known
 - *jodu (Ilesha), odu (Ile-Ife), ayo eleh, ayo odu*.
 - All described games (except *ayo* and *redu*) have in common that are played sowing in **multiple laps**.
 - *Ayo* game is played with this name at least in Lagos, Abeokuta, Ibadan, Oshogbo, Ilobu and Oyo.
 - **In 7 games the harvesting** is performed **only in the opponent's row**:
 - *jekinke, jenje o jekinke (tipus II), olowuka, jodu, jodu (Ilesha), odu (Ile-Ife), ayo odu*.
 - **In 4 games the harvesting** is performed **in both rows**:
 - *sokusowo, odu, ayo eleh, redu*.
 - **8 games** with **only one way of harvesting**:
 - *jekinke, jenje o jekinke (type II), olowuka, jodu, jodu (Ilesha), odu (Ile-Ife), ayo odu, sokusowo*.
 - **3 games** with **two ore more ways of harvesting**:
 - *odu, ayo eleh, redu*.
- All olopon games described here (except *redu*) are only played in **counterclockwise direction**. In *redu* the direction of play is both clockwise and counterclockwise and is played with a curious way of sowing, moving in zigzag.

Contextualization of the research

In the following lines are reported 7 different olopon games from southwestern Nigeria and some variants or other manners to call them in an effort to advertise the richness and vitality of this subfamily of games.

A total amount of **11 olopon games** are described. These games are played in Lagos, Ibadan, Abeokuta, Ilesha, Oshogbo, Ile-Ife, Ilobu and Oyo.

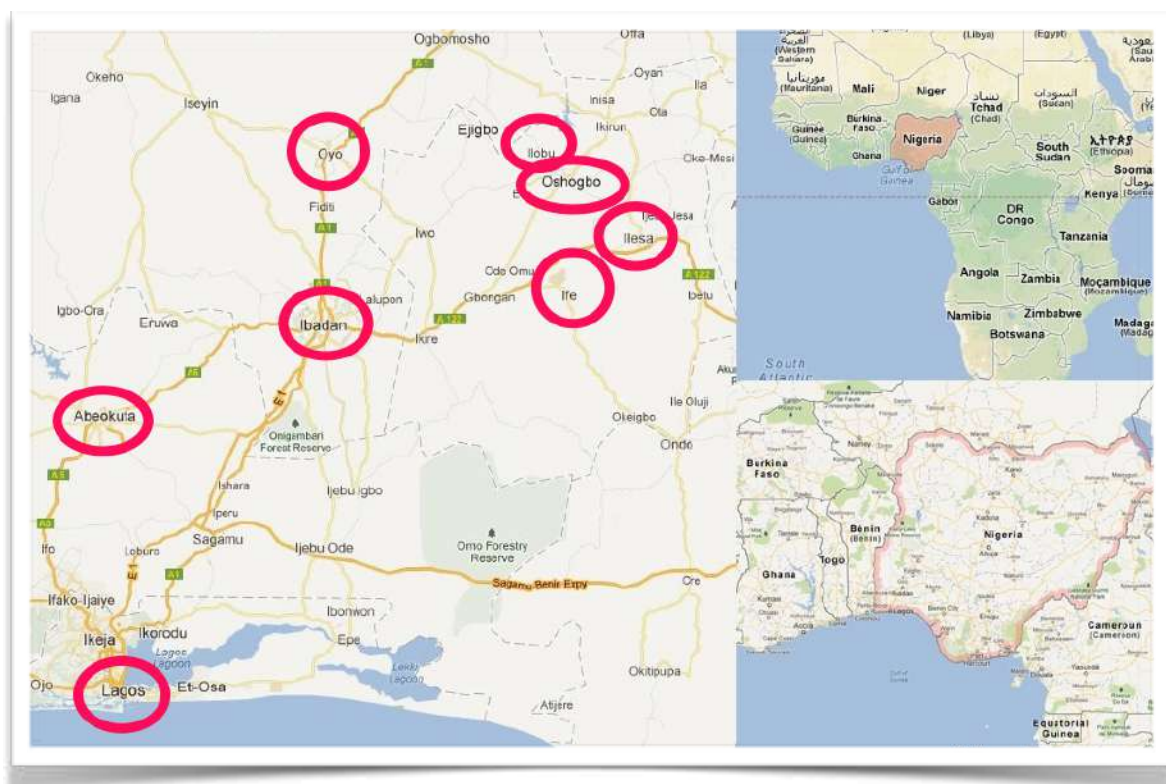


Fig.9: A total amount of 11 games were reported from 8 venues in southwestern Nigeria.

For each game was collected or attempted to collect at least the following information: name of the game and meaning; main informant(s), venue, date of research; and game summary (type of board, number of counters, initial arrangement, direction of play, type of seeding, where and how is the harvesting performed, goal of the game, when and how the game ends).

Rules of 11 Olopon games reported

1. Jekinke. Harvesting is performed in the following hole to the empty hole in the opponent's side where reaches the last seed of a lap.³

Name of the game: Jekinke. "Je ki n je" means in Yoruba language: "Let me eat".

Main informant: anonymous informants, Yoruba males.



Fig.10: Carving in stone by Suzanne Wenger. Sacred Forest in the outskirts of Osogbo, Nigeria. July 19th, 2009.

Photo: Vicenta Canal.

Venue: Ile-Ife, in the Nigerian State of Osun.

Date of the research: July 9th, 2009.

Game summary of Jekinke:

- **Board:** 2x6, two rows of six holes. Wooden board.
- **Pieces:** 48 seeds (24 per player).
- **Initial arrangement:** 4 seeds in each hole.

³ Other informants from Ile-Ife and Osogbo, however, tells us that they use the term "Je n je" or "Je ki n Je" to refer to Ayo.

- **Direction of play:** counterclockwise.
- **Seeding:** play with multiple laps. The seeds are placed one by one into the ensuing holes.
- **Harvesting:** captures are only performed in the opponent's side. When your last seed of a lap falls into one of the opponent's empty holes, you move this last seed just dropped to the next hole and all the seeds of this last hole are captured and also the last seed just moved. All these seeds are removed from the board.
- **Aim of the game:** to capture the most seeds.
- **The game ends...:** when a player cannot play any hole or when the game is "looping". The players capture the remaining seeds in the own side of the board.



Fig. 11: Adeniji Eunice tell us the meaning of the word Jekinke. In Yoruba language it means: "let me eat". Photo: Vicenta Canal. July 7th, 2009 in Ibadan, Oyo State capital.

2. Jenje or Jekinke (type II). Another name for Ayo.

Name of the game: Jenje or Jekinke. "Je ki n je" means in Yoruba language: "Let me eat". Also known as Ayo.

Principal informant: Adeniji Eunice, Yoruba woman from Ile-Ife, in the Nigerian State of Osun.

Venue: Ibadan, Oyo State capital.

Date of the research: July 7th, 2009.

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Game summary of Ayo (or Jenje or Jekinja type II):

- **Board:** 2×6, two rows of six holes. Wooden board.
- **Pieces:** 48 seeds (24 per player).
- **Initial arrangement:** 4 seeds in each hole.
- **Direction of play:** counterclockwise.
- **Seeding:** play is with simple lap. The seeds are placed one by one into the ensuing holes.
- **Harvesting:** captures are only performed in the opponent's side. If the last seed sown falls into an opponent's hole making an amount of 2 or 3 seeds. If the precedent hole contains 2 or 3 seeds as well, these are also captured and removed, and so on but no crossing the limits of the row. It is not allowed to do a move which captures all of your opponent's seeds in one turn.



Fig.12 and Fig.13: Adeniji Eunice and John Bau show us how they play different games (dug holes in the ground because there was not any wooden board during the interview) in Ibadan, Osun State. Photos: Vicenta Canal. July 7th, 2009.

- **Aim of the game:** to capture the most seeds.
- **The game ends...:** when a player cannot play any hole or when the game is "looping". The players capture the remaining seeds in the own side of the board. Also by mutual agreement the players can agree the end of the game. In this case the players capture the remaining seeds.

3. Sokusowo. Harvesting is performed before seeding.

Name of the game: Sokusowo. "Sokusowo" means in Yoruba language: "Stone in hand".

Principal informant: Simon Adediran, Yoruba man from Ilesa, in the Nigerian State of Osun.

Venue: Ilesa, Osun State.

Date of the research: July 10th, 2009.

Game summary of Sokusowo:

- **Board:** 2×6, two rows of six holes. Wooden board.
- **Pieces:** 48 seeds (24 per player).



Fig. 14: Bernat Casanovas and Jordi Climent are doing the fieldwork in Ile-Ife (Osun State). Photo: Vicenta Canal. July 9th, 2009.

- **Initial arrangement:** 4 seeds in each hole.
- **Direction of play:** counterclockwise.
- **Seeding:** play with multiple laps. The seeds are placed one by one into the ensuing holes.
- **Harvesting:** captures can be performed in any row, in your own row and in the opponent player's row. Capturing is performed before seeding. If a player picks up the seeds contained into a hole, this player catches one and keeps it on the other hand or removes it from the board before to sow the remaining seeds.
- **Aim of the game:** to capture the most seeds.

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- **The game ends...:** when a player or both have their own holes with no seeds or with a single seed, the game ends. The players capture the remaining seeds in the own side of the board.

4. Olowuka. Ayo game with multiple laps.

Name of the game: Olowuka. "Olowuka" has an uncertain meaning.

Principal informant: Adekunle Ogun, Yoruba man from Osogbo, in the Nigerian State of Osun.

Venue: Osogbo, Osun State.

Date of the research: July 20, 2009.



Fig. 15: A variant of Jodu is played in Ilesa (Osun State). The single seed (which determines the harvesting of the contents into the opposite hole) is not captured. Photo: Bernat Casanovas. July 9th, 2009.

Game summary of Olowuka:

- **Board:** 2×6, two rows of six holes.
- **Pieces:** 48 (24 per player).
- **Initial arrangement:** 4 seeds in each hole.
- **Direction of play:** counterclockwise.
- **Seeding:** play with multiple laps. The seeds are placed one by one into the ensuing holes.
- **Harvesting:** captures are only performed in the opponent's side. If the last seed falls into an opponent hole making a final total of 2 or 3 seeds. If the precedent hole contains 2 or 3

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seeds as well, these are also captured and removed, and so on but without crossing the limits of the territory or row.

- **Aim of the game:** to capture the most seeds.
- **The game ends...:** when a player can not play any hole or when the game is "looping". The players capture the remaining seeds in the own side of the board.

5. Jodu. All the seeds of the hole opposite to empty hole where reaches the last seed of a lap are captured and also this last single seed sown.

Name of the game: Jodu. "Jòdú" means "You move around the board".



Fig. 16: Ayo game is called Odu in Ile-Ife (Osun State). This kind of Odu (Odu type II or Odu Ile-Ife) is played with the same rules as Ayo. Photo: Vicenta Canal. July 9th, 2009.

Principal informant: Adeniji Eunice, Yoruba woman from Ile-Ife, in the Nigerian State of Osun.

Venue: Ibadan, Oyo State capital.

Date of the research: July 7, 2009.

Game summary of Jodu:

- **Board:** 2×6, two rows of six holes.
- **Pieces:** 48 (24 per player).
- **Initial arrangement:** 4 seeds in each hole.

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- **Direction of play:** counterclockwise.
- **Seeding:** play with multiple laps. The seeds are placed one by one into the ensuing holes.
- **Harvesting:** captures are only performed in the opponent's side. The player captures all the seeds of the hole on the opposite side of the empty hole and also the last single seed sown. These seeds are removed.
- **Aim of the game:** to capture the most seeds.
- **The game ends...:** when a player can not play any hole or when the game is "looping". The players capture the remaining seeds in the own side of the board.

6. Jodu (Ilesa). A variant of Jodu: the last single seed (that determines the harvesting of contents into the opposite hole) is not captured.

Name of the game: Jodu (Ilesa) or Jodu (type II). "Jòdú" means "You move around the board".

Principal informant: Anonymous informants, Yoruba men from Ilesa, in the Nigerian State of Osun.

Venue: Ilesa, in Osun State.

Date of the research: July 10th, 2009.

Game summary of Jodu (Ilesa) or Jodu (type II):

- **Board:** 2×6, two rows of six holes.
- **Pieces:** 48 seeds (24 per player).
- **Initial arrangement:** 4 seeds in each hole.
- **Direction of play:** counterclockwise.
- **Seeding:** play with multiple laps. The seeds are placed one by one into the ensuing holes.
- **Harvesting:** captures are only performed in the opponent's side. The player captures all the seeds of the hole on the opposite side of the reached empty hole but the last single seed sowed is not captured. Captured seeds are removed from the board.
- **Aim of the game:** to capture the most seeds.
- **The game ends...:** when a player can not play any hole or when the game is "looping". The players capture the remaining seeds in the own side of the board.

7. Odu. A game that several harvestings can be performed in the same turn by the player who is seeding and/or by the opponent player.

Name of the game: Odu. "Odu" means: pot or bowl. Also means: path or destination.

Principal informant: Adekunle Ogun, Yoruba man from Osogbo, in the Nigerian State of Osun.

Venue: Osogbo, in Osun State.

Date of the research: July 20th, 2009.

Game summary of Odu:

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- **Board:** 2×6, two rows of six holes.
- **Pieces:** 48 seeds (24 per player).
- **Initial arrangement:** 4 seeds in each hole.
- **Direction of play:** counterclockwise.
- **Seeding:** play with multiple laps. The seeds are placed one by one into the ensuing holes.
- **Harvesting:** captures can be performed in any row, in your own row and in the opponent player's row. Are performed in two ways:
 - if the last seed falls in a hole containing 4 seeds in the opponent's row, with the last one that is sown, these are captured and removed by the player that was sown.



Figs. 17 and 18: Some people playing Ayo game in Ilobu. Photos: Bernat Casanovas. July 21th, 2009.

- when a hole or more holes have exactly 4 seeds at any time during sowing, these are captured and won by each player who owns the hole. A player can capture these seeds while is sowing or while the opponent player is sowing.
- **Aim of the game:** to capture the most seeds.
- **The game ends...:** when there are only 4 seeds on the board or when any player can not to "starve" his opponent. In the first situation the remaining seeds are not for anyone. In the second possibility the remaining seeds are captured by each player according to these seeds are in one row or another.

8. Odu (Ile-Ife). Another name for Ayo game.

Name of the game: Odu (Ile-Ife) or Odu (type II). "Odu" means: pot or bowl. Also means: path or destination.

Principal informant: Anonymous informants, Yoruba men from Ile-Ife, in the Nigerian State of Osun.

Venue: Ile-Ife, Osun State.

Date of the research: July 9th, 2009.

Game summary of Odu (Ile-Ife) or Odu (type II):

The same rules given for *Jenje* or *Jekinje* (type II) or *Ayo*.

9. Ayo Eleh. How Igbo people from Nigeria call Odu.⁴

Name of the game: Ayo Eleh. "Ayo Eleh" has an uncertain meaning.

Principal informant: John Bau, Igbo man who lives in Benin City, capital of the Nigerian State of Edo.

Venue: Ibadan, Oyo State capital.

Date of the research: July 7th, 2009.

Game summary of Ayo Eleh:

The same rules given for *Odu*.

10. Ayo Odu. How Igbo people from Nigeria call Ayo.

Name of the game: Ayo Odu. "Ayo Odu" has an uncertain meaning.

Principal informant: John Bau, Igbo man who lives in Benin City, capital of the Nigerian State of Edo.

Venue: Ibadan, Oyo State capital.

Date of the research: July 7th, 2009.

Game summary of Ayo Odu:

The same rules given for *Jenje* or *Jekinje* (type II) or *Ayo*.

11. Redu. A game that is played in zig-zag and has different ways of harvesting.

Name of the game: Redu or Reodu. The name "re(o)du" has an uncertain meaning.

⁴ *Ayo Eleh* is described by Akan people from Ghana as *Ba-awa*. There are at least three ways to mention the same game: *Odu* by Yoruba people from Nigeria; *Ayo Eleh* by Igbo people from Nigeria; and *Ba-awa* by Akan people from Ghana.

Principal informant: Awosemo Bukola, Yoruba man from Ile-Ife, in the Nigerian State of Osun.

Venue: Osogbo, Osun State.

Date of the research: July 22-23th, 2009.

Game summary of Redu:

- **Board:** 2×6, two rows of six holes.
- **Pieces:** 48 (24 per player).
- **Initial arrangement:** 4 seeds in each hole.
- **Direction of play:** clockwise and counter-clockwise.
- **Seeding:** simple lap. It is played with a curious way of sowing, moving in zigzag. When you start seeding from a hole containing a single seed, You must to move it to the opposite hole.
- When a player has two consecutive holes on the own side with a single seed in each, it is allowed to start sowing these two seeds at same time and seeding these in a zigzag.



Fig. 19: Playing a Redu game match. Osogbo on July 23th, 2009. Recording by Bernat Casanovas.

- **Harvesting:** different ways to capture. In your own row when the opponent player is seeding and in the opponent's row when you are seeding.
- When you start seeding from a hole containing one single seed (you must to move it to the opposite hole) if the opposite hole before seeding:
 - was empty. The remaining seed can be captured by the opponent player. This kind of capture is optional. Whether captured or not, it is the turn of the opponent player.

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- contained 1 or 2 seeds. The player who is seeding captures these 2 or 3 seeds there are after seeding and removes these from the board. The turn ends. If you can capture and do not realize, the opponent can force you to do the movement. As a penalty, the opponent player captures the seeds that you should have caught. It is the turn of your opponent player who has punished you. If there is no penalty or neither of the players realize, the seeds remain on the board and can be seeded or be captured in subsequent turns.
- contained 3 or more seeds. There are no captures performed by nobody. The turn ends.
- When you start seeding from a hole containing 2 seeds (you must to move these in zigzag, first in the hole opposite to the adjacent and the second one in the adjacent hole) if the hole opposite to the adjacent before seeding:
 - was empty. The remaining seed can be captured by the opponent player. This kind of capture is optional. If the capture is performed, the opponent's turn is over with this action.
 - contained 1 or 2 seeds. You capture these 2 or 3 seeds there are after seeding and you remove these from the board. The turn ends.
 - contained 3 or more seeds. There are no captures performed by nobody. The turn ends.
- **Aim of the game:** to capture the most seeds.
- **The game ends...:** when one player have no move left. The opponent player scores the remaining seeds in the own side.

Discussion

In certain areas of Africa (as in the case of southwestern Nigeria) Mancala games were most played by heads or at least by mature and old men. This fact has been seen in some societies as an important educational tool for teaching prevailing social values built by the elderly. This does not mean that women and children do not know how to play and they don't play these games. A woman over 80 years old told us that when she was a girl she knew at least 8 ways to play but no longer remembered. Indeed, as explained Adeniji Eunice⁵, nowadays is common that some Yoruba women with paid job play at home with their children. They also play with their husbands but never in public places. It is frowned upon and it is considered presumptuous for children or women to play against men in a public place. We did not see women or children playing ayo or other olopon games in the streets. The real hidden reason for these restrictions lies in preserving the reputation of the man. For a woman or a child get to win a man in a public place or just try to play may be an offense or may harm the established power of men. However, traditionally if a child grows up and becomes a man without having learned how to play could be evidence of an antisocial disposition. It is hoped that these children play each other.

In collecting and classifying information for research, some questions remain unanswered or the answers are not conclusive. How do you explain that games do not change across long distances or over time as the case of ayo game? As De Voogt said (1999) the stability of rules can only be explained if large groups of players moved from one place to another. Only where contact between players would be frequent could the game become stable and could one variation start to dominate. The rules of Ayo game (known with others names: awale, awale lete, awele, ayo odu, jenje, wari, oware) are almost identical in Nigeria, Ghana, Ivory Coast. And also in the other side of the Atlantic, in the Caribbean (as Antigua and Barbuda, Barbados) and in some countries of South America as Guyana and Ecuador (Climent, 2013), due to the diaspora of African slaves brought over by European colonialism. However, if a game is taught to other players individually elsewhere or whether the game travels to another area and it is occasionally

⁵ Adeniji Eunice, a.k.a. Iya Sango, the director of National Museum Alesinloye in Ibadan.

introduced, it explains that the rules of the games change across distances. However, in these cases, the game may have some variations on few particular aspects of the rules.

On the other hand, it is known that mancala games in a restricted area vary widely between venues that are within walking distance or in the same place as we saw in this research. Even we report a game (redu) that brings different ways of sowing and harvesting. How do you explain that in a small area are there many variations and different games? Why are there in a certain area different ways of sowing and harvesting between the olopon games? Keep in mind that the people were very isolated in this area of Nigeria. Is the isolation the reason to explain the different ways of sowing and harvesting between these games? If the same rules in different places are the result of human migration, we might explain (in part) that in a small place there are different and unique Mancala games as a result of isolation.

All games described in this fieldwork were played by small groups of people. It was strange to me that people who were playing a certain mancala game in a town did not know which Olopon games were playing in another neighboring village. We can't confirm that in a particular region or town there is a dominant game. This would be possible only when there are a large number of games played on the same area. In this case, we could confirm that there is a prevalent game in a certain region with local variations and perhaps draw conclusions about the possible migration.

I think it would be unwise to draw general conclusions from the 11 games reported and described in this research. I hope this paper shows that there is a very interesting and unique area in southwestern Nigeria (where even today are preserved various mancala games that are not played anywhere else) which has been little studied. If I can encourage new researches by presenting this modest fieldwork then I'll be very happy!

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Ayo olopon & other games

Some newly described mancala games
from southwestern Nigeria

